

To the extent that the roots of the allegorical approach that flourished in Alexandria during the third century were already present, they would also be a negative factor. Since Philo of Alexandria was at the height of his influence when the first Christians arrived there, it may be that his allegorical interpretation of the O.T. began to rub off on the young church already in the first century. Since an allegorist is going to impose his own ideas on the text anyway, he would presumably have fewer inhibitions about altering it—precise wording would not be a high priority.

The school of literary criticism that existed at Alexandria would also be a negative factor, if it influenced the Church at all, and W.R. Farmer argues that it did. “But there is ample evidence that by the time of Eusebius the Alexandrian text-critical practices were being followed in at least some of the scriptoria where New Testament manuscripts were being produced. Exactly when Alexandrian text-critical principles were first used... is not known.”¹ He goes on to suggest that the Christian school founded in Alexandria by Pantaeus, around 180, was bound to be influenced by the scholars of the great library of that city. The point is, the principles used in attempting to ‘restore’ the works of Homer would not be appropriate for the NT writings when appeal to the Autographs, or exact copies made from them, was still possible.

Conclusion

What answer do the “four controlling factors” give to our question? The four speak with united voice: “The Aegean area was the best qualified to protect, transmit and attest the true text of the NT writings.” This was true in the 2nd century; it was true in the 3rd century; it continued to be true in the 4th century. So in AD 350, the middle of the 4th century, where should we go to find the most correct copies of the NT? To the Aegean area; Egypt would be the last place to go. If the transmission of the NT Text was reasonably normal, the Aegean area would continue to have the best Text down through the succeeding centuries. But there are those who have argued that the transmission was not normal, so to that question I now turn.

Was the Transmission Normal?

Beginning with Saul of Tarsus, Christians were persecuted here and there throughout the Roman Empire until Constantine started relief in AD 312. The persecutions included the sporadic destruction of copies of the

¹ W.R. Farmer, *The Last Twelve Verses of Mark* (Cambridge: University Press, 1974), pp. 14-15. He cites B.H. Streeter, *The Four Gospels: A Study of Origins* (London: Macmillan and Co., 1924), pp. 111, 122-23.